

A *database* is a program that allows you to store and retrieve information. Good databases are highly optimized to do this efficiently and reliably with large amounts of data.

Databases store most of the world's information. Whenever you retrieve information from a website or post to a website, that information is being read from or written to a database. Many of the projects programmers work on interact with a database.

Structured Query Language (SQL) is a language written specifically to interact with databases, but you don't need to know SQL to work with a database. Many languages and frameworks generate SQL for you, so you can work with the database through those languages. If you're serious about programming, however, it's a good idea to learn SQL.

SQLite, PostgreSQL, MySQL, SQL Server, and Oracle are the most common databases used in programming.